

The 72-hour playbook.

What to do in the first three days after a layoff or departure. Day by day. Not month by month — day by day.

IF YOU TAKE NOTHING ELSE AWAY

The five things that matter most

- File for unemployment benefits on Day 1, not Day 30. Eligibility windows are strict and money takes time to start.
- Calculate your exact runway in hours, not days. Know the number before you do anything else.
- Do not apply to jobs in the first 72 hours. Use the time to orient — not to spray.
- Tell people before you tell LinkedIn. Personal messages to key contacts first.
- The COBRA decision has a 60-day window but act in 30. Decide this week, not next month.

The first 72 hours after a layoff are disorienting. The goal is not to fix everything. It's to not make any decisions you'll regret while still in shock.

Do these things in this order. Everything else can wait until Week 2.

DAY 1 — TODAY

Stabilize. Don't optimize.

- ☐ File for unemployment benefits online at your state's department of labor website. Do this today. Benefits take 2–4 weeks to begin; filing late delays the start date.
- ☐ Calculate your exact financial runway: liquid savings ÷ monthly expenses = months of runway. Write down the number.
- ☐ Make a COBRA note: you have 60 days to elect, but decide within 30. Note the deadline date.
- ☐ Change your LinkedIn status: remove current company if appropriate, but do NOT post anything yet.
- ☐ Text or call 2–3 close colleagues personally — before they hear from someone else. Keep it brief: "I'm out as of today. Let's catch up soon." No LinkedIn announcement today.
- ☐ Cancel or pause any non-essential subscriptions. Small decisions with no downside.
- ☐ Do nothing else work-related today. Take a walk. Tell your family. That's enough for Day 1.

NEXTCAPTER · BENEFITS & FINANCIAL BRIDGE

Run your COBRA vs. ACA calculation and get your precise runway number in your first NextChapter session. Takes 10 minutes.
launchyournextchapter.com

DAY 2

Organize. Don't apply.

- ☐ Take your Hireability Assessment on NextChapter. One hour. Gives you an honest starting picture.
- ☐ Write your story — three sentences. What happened, what you learned or what changed, where you're focused. Say it out loud until it sounds like a statement, not a defense.
- ☐ Export your LinkedIn connections as a CSV (Settings → Data Privacy → Get a copy of your data). You'll need this for the Warm Path Finder later.
- ☐ Write down your top 5–7 career accomplishments with specific numbers while they're fresh in your mind.

- ☐ Identify five references. Message them personally today. Get their personal email address.
- ☐ Do not apply to any jobs today. You are not ready yet and premature applications go nowhere.

NEXTCHAPTER · HIREABILITY ASSESSMENT

Your Hireability Report gives you an honest picture of where you stand before you approach the market — so your first moves are the right ones. Free at launchournextchapter.com

DAY 3

Define your target. Update your presence.

- ☐ Define your target role with specificity: function, level, industry or two, geography. "VP Finance at a Series B-D healthcare or fintech company, remote or New York." The more specific, the more useful every conversation becomes.
- ☐ Update your LinkedIn headline. Not "Seeking new opportunities" — name your function, level, and one differentiator: "CFO | Healthcare & Fintech | Building finance functions that scale."
- ☐ Set Open to Work to Recruiters only (not the public green ring — it signals desperation to some hiring managers).
- ☐ Update your About section: one clear paragraph of what you do and what you're looking for next.
- ☐ Now you're ready to tell your network. Post a brief LinkedIn update or send personal notes to the 10 people most likely to connect you to your next role. Keep it specific about what you're looking for.

NEXTCHAPTER · NARRATIVE BUILDER

Victoria generates your LinkedIn headline, About section, résumé summary, and verbal story from a single 20-minute conversation — all consistent across every surface.

WEEK 1 — AFTER THE FIRST 72 HOURS

Foundation before activation

- ☐ Complete the Career Narrative Workshop (download from your Success Toolkit)
- ☐ Have the COBRA vs. ACA decision made and documented
- ☐ Have a preliminary résumé update done (not final — but current and accurate)
- ☐ Have 5 references confirmed
- ☐ Have your story — three sentences — polished and practiced
- ☐ Begin the first three conversations with people who know your work

WHAT WEEK 1 IS NOT FOR

It is not for applying to 50 jobs. It is not for redoing your entire résumé from scratch. It is not for attending every networking event you can find. The foundation must come before the activation. Candidates who rush activation in week one spend week six wondering why nothing is working.